

Grade 8 – Civics and Economics in Action (Draft)

Overview

In grade 8, students will utilize past knowledge and understanding to expand their focus on the core concepts and principles underlying America's democracy; the structure and limits of the national government as set forth in the United States Constitution, including an examination of democratic ideals; and the role of the citizen in a democratic society. Students will collaborate to identify a problem(s); develop solutions that would require government involvement; and participate in student-led civics projects focused on developing civic knowledge, skills, dispositions, and media literacy. Students will also learn about the workings of local, national, and global economies and develop an understanding of the decision-making processes of individuals, businesses, and governments and how they are connected. Gaining an understanding of economic resources, such as human capital, land, technology, and investments, and how they play a role in big-picture decision making in a global environment will assist students in making informed decisions in a wide variety of contexts.

Looking Back

In grade 7, students built on their knowledge of Vermont and United States politics, geography, economics, and history as they re-visited the sectional conflicts over slavery that continued into Reconstruction and beyond and led to the long struggle in the 19th and 20th centuries for civil rights.

Inquiry

Why inquiry? Using inquiry as an instructional model for the teaching of social studies allows students to authentically ask questions, search for and analyze evidence, and provide explanations and arguments to challenges facing their world.



The inquiry instructional model is driven by authentic questions or problems that have relevance for children. Students learn content, skills, and dispositions as they seek answers to questions and as they apply their learning to take informed action. Pioneered by Dewey (1938), inquiry is an attempt to make classroom experiences feel more like the authentic, curiosity-driven experiences that motivate learning outside of school. ([Using Inquiry to Prepare Students for College, Career, and Civic Life](#), elementary edition, p. 22)

The Inquiry Arc is defined in Dimension 1 (questioning) of the [College, Career, and Civic Life \(C3\) Framework for Social Studies State Standards](#). In this Framework, Dimension 3 (evidence sourcing), and Dimension 4 (communicating), as well as some evidence indicators found within Dimension 2 – History, have been combined with Dimension 1 into a singular Inquiry Process, as evidenced below. This Inquiry Process begins in the elementary grades and increases in depth and complexity as it spans through high school, preparing students to spiral their learning and skill acquisition in the social studies for college and career readiness.

Inquiry Process (K-12): Students act as social scientists as they ask questions, think critically, solve problems, and share conclusions.

C3 Indicators (6-8):

Constructing Compelling and Supporting Questions: D1.1, 2, 3; His. 12

Gathering and Evaluating Sources: D2. His. 6, 10, 12, 13; D3. 1, 2, 3

Communicating and Critiquing Conclusions: D2. His. 16; D4. 1, 2, 4

Overarching Themes:

- Foundations and Roles
- Economics and Policy
- Geography (in grades 6 and 7)
- Civic Participation in a Democracy

Note: Free Civics Curricula

While there are curriculum materials for purchase, here are three free resources that could guide your development and are aligned with this Framework:

- MA - [Civics Project Guidebook](#)
- New Jersey Center for Civic Education at Rutgers University - [Curriculum Guide for Middle School Civics](#)
- Supporting Readiness through Vital Civic Education (SRVCE) - [Curriculum and Teacher Toolkit](#)
- Facing History and Ourselves- [Civic Education Curriculum Collection](#)

Civics

Theme: Foundations and Roles

Civic and Political Institutions

D2.Civ.1.6-8. Distinguish the powers and responsibilities of citizens, political parties, interest groups, and the media in a variety of governmental and nongovernmental contexts.

D2.Civ.2.6-8. Explain specific roles played by citizens (such as voters, jurors, taxpayers, members of the armed forces, petitioners, protesters, and office-holders).

D2.Civ.3.6-8. Examine the origins, purposes, and impact of constitutions, laws, treaties, and international agreements.

D2.Civ.4.6-8. Explain the powers and limits of the three branches of government, public officials, and bureaucracies at different levels in the United States and in other countries.

D2.Civ.5.6-8. Explain the origins, functions, and structure of government with reference to the U.S. Constitution, state constitutions, and selected other systems of government.

D2.Civ.6.6-8. Describe the roles of political, civil, and economic organizations in shaping people's lives.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to explain the philosophical and historical foundations of the American political system. Students will be able to explain how civic engagement, legal obligations, and constitutional protections shape participation in the political process and influence democratic institutions.	Founding philosophers/documents • Rousseau, Montesquieu, Hobbes, Locke • English Bill of Rights, Magna Carta, Declaration of Independence, United States Constitution (Preamble, Articles, Amendments), Vermont Constitution, Tribal Constitutions, Mayflower Compact, Articles of Confederation Constitution (US and Vermont) – framework (preamble, articles, amendments); structure and function Citizenship defined; how to become a citizen; naturalization; legal permanent resident; immigrant; the rights and responsibilities of citizens (e.g., voting, serving as a juror, paying taxes, serving in the military, running for and holding elected office) as compared to non-citizens Political Change – Elections/right to vote; Interest groups; Lobbying; Public policy; Social movements; Grassroots/grass tops; political protests Principles of the Constitution – rule of law, judicial review, popular sovereignty, checks and balances, separation of power, federalism Types of Governments – Autocracy; Democracy; Dictatorship; Oligarchy; Republic; Monarchy Fundamental Principles, Ideals, and Values of American Political and Civic Life – liberty, the common good, justice, equality, tolerance, law and order, due process, rights of individuals, diversity, civic unity, patriotism, constitutionalism, popular sovereignty, property rights, domestic tranquility, and representative democracy

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Continue Students will be able to explain how the values and principles of the Constitution influence American institutions and practices and continue to shape the structure, functions, and practices of American political and legal institutions. Students will be able to explain the leadership structure of the state and national governments and the function in each branch of government.	Political Leadership • Criteria for electing leaders; the process of elections in the legislative and executive branches and the process of nomination/confirmation of individuals in the judicial and executive. • Evaluate information related to elections (e.g., policy positions and debates among candidates, campaign financing, campaign advertising, influence of news media and social media, and data relating to voter turnout in elections). • Importance/opportunities of/for civic participation; volunteering; media literacy National and State Government – Structure • Vermont government – a. the executive branch (governor and agencies), b. the legislative branch (state representatives and state senators), c. courts of law (Supreme Judicial Court, lower court system) • The leadership structure of the government of Vermont and the function of each branch.

Civic Virtues and Democratic Principles

D2.Civ.7.6-8. Apply civic virtues and democratic principles in school and community settings.

D2.Civ.8.6-8. Analyze ideas and principles contained in the founding documents of the United States, and explain how they influence the social and political system.

D2.Civ.10.6-8. Explain the relevance of personal interests and perspectives, civic virtues, and democratic principles when people address issues and problems in government and civil society.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to explain the balance between common good and individual freedom. Students will be able to identify current and past local, state, national decisions that may conform or conflict with democratic ideals.	Individual and Common Good Classical republicanism, individual rights, natural rights, social contract, liberty, civic virtue Democratic ideals Limited government, popular sovereignty, separation of powers, checks and balances, republicanism, federalism, judicial review, individual rights, common good, rule of law, civil rights, equality Decisions that conform/conflict to ideals Eugenics; 13th,14th, 15th, and 19th amendments; Indian Removal Act of 1835; Jim Crow laws; Dawes Act; Compromise of 1877; State and Federal recognition of American Indians; Supreme Court precedents; GI Bill; Black Codes; New Deal; Chinese Exclusion Act; Redlining; Title IX

Rules, Processes, and Laws

D2.Civ.11.6-8. Differentiate among procedures for making decisions in the classroom, school, civil society, and local, state, and national government in terms of how civic purposes are intended.

D2.Civ.12.6-8. Assess specific rules and laws (both actual and proposed) as means of addressing public problems.

D2.Civ.13.6-8. Analyze the purposes, implementation, and consequences of public policies in multiple settings.

D2.Civ.14.6-8. Compare historical and contemporary means of changing societies, and promoting the common good.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to examine how conflicts are resolved peacefully in a democratic society. Students will be able to participate in appropriate citizen actions to address community issue(s).	Conflict Resolution: litigation, mitigation, negotiation, arbitration Civil Discourse: tolerance, pride, avoidance, perspectives, positions, underlying interests, respect Importance of civic participation - volunteering; advocate for existing legislation; introduce a new piece of legislation; organize support to increase awareness and implement new policies and practices related to their issue.

Resources

[Certain Unalienable Rights](#) - National Archives: Students will explore the Declaration of Independence as an artifact, a primary source, and a persuasive text. Students explore the document's important sections and evaluate the persuasive elements of the Declaration of Independence. This Civics for All of US distance learning program is available for groups of 10 or more students free of charge. Each program will be led by one of our educators located at National Archives sites, the Center for Legislative Archives, and Presidential Libraries across the country. After submitting your program request, you will be connected to an available National Archives educator to confirm your reservation. We require that the

requesting educator or another educator from your institution be present during the student distance learning program to observe the session and support classroom management. Programs are also offered as [regularly scheduled interactive webinars](#). Registration is required, but there is no minimum attendance prerequisite.

[Civics and Government](#) - PBS Learning Media: Search interactive lessons, videos, and other PBS-related resources within the Topic Area of The American Political System to find resources in “American Documents,” “American Identity and Diversity,” “American Laws and Rights,” and “The Practice of American Citizenship,” among others.

[Democracy in Dialogue Virtual Exchange Program](#) - Smithsonian Institute: Become a Smithsonian Virtual Exchange Facilitator and learn how to collaboratively design and lead place-based investigations with your students to better understand the stories emanating from your hometown. Share and reflect with another community in another corner of the country. Celebrate the commonalities and the differences.

[Educator Resources](#) - Educating for American Democracy: A clearinghouse for vetted resources; search by grade-level, topic, resource-type.

[Explore the Declaration of Independence](#) - PBS Learning Media: In this interactive lesson, students are guided through a close reading and analysis of the Declaration of Independence, one of the nation’s founding documents. The lesson highlights the Declaration of Independence’s historical context, its Enlightenment influences, and its elevation to one of a handful of revered documents in U.S. history.

[Exploring Local Government](#) - PBS Learning Media: With this interactive image, students can discover the vital role that town government plays in shaping the community and impacting the daily lives of its residents. Explore various town departments and learn how they provide essential services, maintain infrastructure, and ensure public safety. When you understand the roles of town departments, you are more likely to be able to change or have an impact on your community. Also included are teaching tips, discussion questions, and an independent student activity.

[Freedom and Unity](#) - The Center for Cartoon Studies: A downloadable version of the Center’s “Graphic Guide to Civics and Democracy in Vermont.”

[Getting to Know Your Neighbor](#) - Statistics in Schools: Suggested for grades 5,6 but can be used for students to learn more about their community when they research public policy issues. To introduce demographic characteristics to students, teachers will help them create a population pyramid. Then, students will use an online tool called QuickFacts to find census data on demographic characteristics for a county in 2024. They will compare it to older data from the same county to find changes and trends over time. They will then use QuickFacts to examine data about their school’s county.

Students will use this information to help them understand how business owners and community leaders use data on demographic characteristics to make decisions.

International Affairs - **iCivics**: Students learn about the complex interactions that exist in our globalized world. They examine the evolution of diplomacy and international interdependence by looking at recent and historical global events.

Multiple Grade 7-8 lessons on the Constitution - **Center for Civic Education**: Lessons adapted from the We the People Level 2 text, with lesson purpose, objectives, terms to understand, readings, supplemental sources, and activities. Lessons include: “What is the Federal System Created by the Constitution?”, “Why do We Need a Government?”, and “How Can Citizens participate?”, among others.

On Your Own: Your Legal Rights @ Eighteen - The Vermont Bar Association has published this 6th edition online booklet covering topics such as “If You Are a Victim of a Crime,” “Rights to Free Speech,” “Identity Theft,” and “Welcome to the Voting Booth.” Originally designed as a resource for students prior to high school graduation, this booklet provides valuable information for all Vermonters.

The Constitution - **iCivics**: Students will learn how our Constitution was created and what some of its key characteristics are. They will also explore key amendments to the Constitution and their application in protecting citizens' rights.

The Resource Center - **Center for Civic Education**: Free resources including curricular crosswalks, lesson plans, online courses, “60-Second Daily Podcast” and “The Constitution EXPLAINED” videos.

This is What Democracy Looks Like - **The Center for Cartoon Studies**: Download this 32-page comic book that explains what democracy actually means and how the whole thing works. You can also download a free PDF of our [teaching resource guide](#), which provides a robust lesson plan that includes a week’s worth of activities and discussion questions that aligns with a C3 framework.

Vermont Classroom Blueprint - **Vermont Office of the Secretary of State**: A K-12 ‘blueprint’ providing resources and lesson plans for active civic engagement in your classroom.

Economics

Theme: Economics and Policy

Note: Economic Decision Making Indicators are not in the grade 8 scope and sequence and can be addressed/assessed in grades 6 and 7.

Exchange and Markets

D2.Eco.8.6-8. Explain how external benefits and costs influence market outcomes.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to explain how government agencies protect investors and regulate financial markets and products.	Federal Reserve Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation (FDIC) Consumer Financial Protection Bureau Consumer Protection Laws: • Truth in Lending Act • Fair Credit Reporting Act • Fair Debt Collection Practices Act • Consumer Product Safety Act

The National Economy

D2.Eco.10.6-8. Explain the influence of changes in interest rates on borrowing and investing.

D2.Eco.11.6-8. Use appropriate data to evaluate the state of employment, unemployment, inflation, total production, income, and economic growth in the economy.

D2.Eco.12.6-8. Explain how inflation, deflation, and unemployment affect different groups.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to explain the economic impact(s) of public policy decisions. Students will be able to explain the factors influencing GDP and how it reflects economic health.	Fiscal policy: cutting/raising taxes Monetary policy: • large government expenditures can lead to higher demand and inflation – could lead to Fed raising interest rates • lack of government expenditures could equal slow down and Fed cut Government investments – infrastructure, healthcare; minimum wage Policy decisions connections to government (all levels), institutions, businesses, individuals Gross Domestic Product, Inflation Rate, Employment Compare and analyze the GDP of the United States with that of other countries.

The Global Economy

D2.Eco.14.6-8. Explain barriers to trade and how those barriers influence trade among nations.

D2.Eco.15.6-8. Explain the benefits and the costs of trade policies to individuals, businesses, and society.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to explain the roles of global economic organizations in shaping economic policies and promoting international economic cooperation. Students will be able to explain the role of central banks and global economic factors in determining exchange rates. Students will be able to explain the concept of international debt and its implications for both developed and developing countries.	World Economic Organizations: International Monetary Fund, World Bank, Organization for Economic Cooperation, World Trade Organization, Oil Producing and Exporting Countries (OPEC) Trade Agreements: United States, Mexico, and Canada Agreement (USMCA); North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA); European Union; African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCTA); Paris Agreement, G7, G8, G20 Treaties and agreements (political and economic), foreign policy, effects of significant world events/trends/developments on the United States; the United Nations role Role of Central Banks (the Federal Reserve): • Set interest rates: Higher interest rates attract foreign investment, which can raise the value of a currency; interest rate manipulation can be used to create a stable economy; inflation means there is too much money in circulation so interest rates are raised or remain high; recession or depression means that consumers are not spending so rates are lowered to encourage bank lending/consumer spending • Control money supply: Printing too much money can weaken a currency; keeping it stable helps maintain value. • Intervene in currency markets: Some central banks buy or sell their own currency to keep it from rising or falling too much.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Continue Students will be able to identify evolving relationships between the United States and other nation-states around the world.	Barriers • Tariffs and protectionism; isolationism; war/conflicts – disrupts trade but creates new industry – female employment Costs of Trade • Import competition Benefits • Businesses – Increased profits; larger markets; global influence • Consumers – lower prices, increased choice

Resources

Analyzing Correlations Between Education and Income - Statistics in Schools: Students will explore maps containing census data from 1950 through 2000. They will analyze how education levels and median household incomes have changed over time and determine how the two might be correlated. Students will also come up with ideas for policies that could help address issues related to income and education.

Fiscal Policy and Monetary Policy: What's the Difference? - Federal Reserve Bank of Richmond: Activities and lesson plans for students to understand the policy differences and the role of the Federal Reserve in influencing the economy.

Illicit: The Dark Trade - National Geographic: Resources are unevenly distributed across the surface of the Earth, and no one country has all the resources it needs. Therefore, each country must trade with others, resulting in a world of global economic interdependence—an exchange between “producers” (those who produce or manufacture goods) and “consumers” (those who purchase or use the goods). The two following activities help students understand the concept of economic interdependence between different countries, and understand terms such as trade, import, and export. A trading simulation will help students understand the conditions that encourage or discourage trade among countries. In

the activities, students will split into country groups and employ product-unit trading cards to represent the net worth of five world countries. They will use these trading cards to obtain goods not available in their country and to disperse goods that their country produces. Students will discover that some commodities are more desirable than others and that shifts in an economic market can directly affect the price of goods.

The Federal Reserve and You - Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia: In this lesson, students view a film segment from The Federal Reserve and You that introduces the Federal Reserve. Using an anticipation/reaction guide, students learn what the Fed is, what it does, and what its impact on the economy is.

The Story of Monetary Policy - Federal Reserve Bank of New York: This lesson plan allows students to discuss the ways in which monetary policy can help reduce periods of economic sickness.

Where Should I Live? Using U.S. Census Bureau Data to Make Decisions - Statistics in Schools: Students can use this lesson as a means to learn and interpret data when they are considering their public policy. Students will use the U.S. Census Bureau's QuickFacts data access tool to examine information about three cities, including population, education, and income data. Students will draw conclusions about life in those three cities to determine which city they would like to live in as an adult.

Why We Pay Taxes - NextGen Personal Finance: This unit 3, lesson 4 lesson helps students understand fiscal policy as they analyze why federal taxes are removed from their paycheck.

History

***Note:** C3 indicators for Historical Sources and Evidence are woven into the Inquiry Process.

Theme: Civic Participation in a Democracy

Change, Continuity, and Context

D2.His.1.6-8. Analyze connections among events and developments in broader historical contexts.

D2.His.2.6-8. Classify series of historical events and developments as examples of change and/or continuity.

D2.His.3.6-8. Use questions generated about individuals and groups to analyze why they, and the developments they shaped, are seen as historically significant.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to explain how the Constitution provides both continuity and flexibility in American government. Students will be able to compare how local, state, and national governments have changed in response to civic action.	Continuity: Three branches, Bill of Rights Flexibility: Amendment process, Elastic Clause, Judicial interpretation (overturned Supreme Court cases) Local: changing school board policies, local protests, Town Meetings; ordinances State: Baker v. Vermont, Civil Union and Marriage equality law; minimum wage increases; environmental protection; Act 250; gun safety legislation National: Civil Rights Movement, Civil Rights Act, Voting Rights Act; Americans with Disabilities Act • 13th, 14th, 15th, 19th, 26th Amendments • Indian Citizenship Act • Stonewall Riots

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to explain how the rights of different groups of people have been limited or expanded throughout history.	• Obergefell v. Hodges • Vermont recognition of Abenaki tribes in 2011-12 • 16- and 17-year-olds can vote in local Brattleboro elections; some municipalities allow non-citizen voting

Perspectives

D2.His.4.6-8. Analyze multiple factors that influenced the perspectives of people during different historical eras.

D2.His.5.6-8. Explain how and why perspectives of people have changed over time.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to explain how social movements and events have changed attitudes about justice and equality.	Abolition and Civil Rights: Key figures: Frederick Douglas, Rosa Parks, Martin Luther King Jr., Civil Rights Act; shift in attitude from segregation to growing support for racial justice Women’s Rights: Seneca Falls Convention, Title IX, Equal Rights Amendment debates; shift from exclusion in voting to leadership, education, and workforce inclusion LGBTQ+: Stonewall Riots, “Don’t Ask, Don’t Tell”, Obergefell v. Hodges; shift from marginalization to legal equality

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Continue Students will be able to explain how Vermont's views on issues have evolved.	Disability Rights: Americans with Disabilities Act shift to inclusion • Black Lives Matter flag raisings • Act 20 • Ethnic Studies initiatives • Baker v. Vermont • School consolidation debates

Causation and Argumentation

D2.His.16.6-8. Organize applicable evidence into a coherent argument about the past.

D2.His.17.6-8. Compare the central arguments in secondary works of history on related topics in multiple media.

Sample C3 Indicator Connections	Sample Content Connections
Students will be able to examine varied evidence from multiple sources and perspectives to develop an argument/solution to the issue.	Importance of Media Literacy Accuracy, confirmation bias, controversy, fabricated news, misinformation, disinformation, benefits and challenges of digital news and social media to a democratic society, assessing the validity of claims and sufficiency of evidence, analyze the point of view and evaluate the claims.

Resources

[Project Community: Engaging All Students in Media Literacy and Public Policy](#) - Center for Civic Education:

Media literacy videos (under three-minutes each) with titles such as “Does a Free Press Support Democracy?” and “Is All Media Biased?” which can be used to engage students in responsible media use as they investigate public policy.

[Public Policy](#) - iCivics: Middle school units “County Solutions Civic Action Plan,” “Media and Influence,” “Persuasive Writing,” and “News Literacy” provide resources as students develop their own public policy.

[Student Forms/Resources](#) - Center for Civic Education: Chose Project Citizen Level 1 or 2 to access student resources that can be completed as they **research public policy**.

[The Art of Persuasion: Using Census Data to Influence Others](#) - Statistics in Schools: Students will incorporate information from the U.S. Census Bureau’s QuickFacts data access tool into an advertisement for a city of their choice. They will use persuasive and advertising techniques to convince others to come to their city.